

SOFIA VALDEZ

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SUMMARY

Mixed-methods UX Researcher independently leading research end-to-end, with outcomes including a 2.5x lift in checkout conversion, a redirected product roadmap, and \$4M in funding secured for a self-built AI tool.

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Mechanical Engineering, Human-AI Interaction | *The University of Texas at Austin* **Aug 2020 – Aug 2025**
NSF Graduate Research Fellow | GEM Fellow | Virginia & Ernest Cockrell Jr. Fellow

B.S., Mechanical Engineering, Product Development | *The University of Texas at Austin* **Aug 2016 – May 2020**
Minor: McCombs School of Business Foundations | HSF Scholar | Tau Beta Pi | Engineering Ambassador

EXPERIENCE

User Research Coordinator (Contract) | *Apple* **May 2026 – Jun 2026**

- Developed study protocols and conducted user studies as part of the Human Factors team.
- Automated data collection with AI, **cutting processing time by 97.5%**.

User Experience Researcher (Contract) | *Panda Mobile, T-Mobile Powered Carrier* **Sep 2024 – Mar 2025**

- Conducted usability interviews to diagnose onboarding drop-off** points and translated findings into product requirements and a benchmarked redesign that **drove 2.5x checkout conversion** within one month.
- Initiated market research on a new target segment** (25 in-depth interviews) and synthesized findings into a company-wide strategic presentation that **redirected multiple product and marketing investments**.

Doctoral Researcher, Human-AI Interaction | *The University of Texas at Austin* **Aug 2020 – Aug 2025**

- Built an AI-powered interactive design application in Python** from the ground up as a research instrument, including dataset generation, generative AI model training, and AI tool and interface development.
- Independently designed and executed mixed-methods user studies with 105 participants end-to-end**, from recruitment to usability testing and data analysis, to measure how agency in AI-assisted tasks shapes user behavior, attitudes, and performance.
- Triangulated qualitative survey data to quantitative interaction data** via statistical and sentiment analysis.
- Collaborated with industry partners to secure \$4M+ in funding to operationalize the AI-powered application** and conducted **50+ customer and stakeholder interviews** to drive iterative UX improvements.

Product Development Teaching Assistant | *The University of Texas at Austin* **Aug 2021 – May 2022**

- Guided student teams through the **full product design and development lifecycle of industry-sponsored projects (including NASA)**, from customer discovery and competitive analysis to PRDs and prototyping.

Data Science (Intern) | *National Renewable Energy Laboratory* **Jun 2021 – Aug 2021**

- Resolved a SQL bottleneck in a data pipeline processing 1M+ readings per minute, cutting time by 98.6%.
- Built a machine learning model to predict energy efficiency months ahead for proactive resource planning.

Research Engineer (Intern) | *Halliburton* **Jun 2019 – Aug 2019**

- Conducted contextual inquiry** across two field sites and **interviewed 50+ operators, engineers, and technicians to diagnose a \$200K/year sand clogging problem** from root cause to operational impact.
- Implemented 2 reactive solutions** (including a custom filtration system); **proposed 1 proactive redesign**.

SKILLS

Research: Primary & secondary research, generative research, market research, competitive analysis, interviews, contextual inquiry, usability testing, thematic analysis, heuristic evaluations, IRB & research ethics compliance

Technical: Python, R, SQL, Matlab, Figma, Mixpanel, deep learning, statistical analysis, data visualization, Agile/Scrum